

# Gumball Dreams: Live Theatre in VR

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## ABSTRACT

Since 2020 Ferryman Collective has been pushing the boundaries of what is possible in theater by using VR technology to give audiences the ability to become a part of the story in a fully immersive way. VR theatre offers the feeling of embodiment and immersion that closely mimics the feeling of going to a theater in person, with the added interactivity of gaming, and the cinematic qualities of film. Ferryman Collective productions have been well received at the most prestigious festivals in the world and garnered many awards along the way.

*Gumball Dreams* centers around the story of an ancient alien on the precipice of transitioning from this life to the next. Experience an excerpt of Ferryman Collective and Screaming Color's award-winning production, *Gumball Dreams*. A one-on-one journey with an actor in VR for a 15-minute portion of this immersive theater play.

## CCS CONCEPTS

• **Computing methodologies** → Computer graphics; Graphics systems and interfaces; Virtual reality; • **Human-centered computing** → Human computer interaction (HCI); Interaction paradigms; Virtual reality.

## KEYWORDS

Performance, Theater, Immersive, Virtual Reality

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## 1 INTRODUCTION

Nothing compares to the magic of a live performance. Like quantum particles appearing out of nowhere, a connection is made and then gone, never to be experienced in quite the same way again. Motion picture performers often strive for perfection, to capture that

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perfectly honest moment. However, live theatrical performances offer something different, the inherent thrill of the unexpected. The instant an unrehearsed event happens on stage, we watch the actor react with honesty in the moment as they adjust and move the story along; the honest moments resonate the most. The rules of live theatre dictate that unforeseen glitches can't be 'fixed in post,' as pre-recorded experiences are able to do. Live theater lives in its honest imperfection, like the messy rawness of life, or the whimsical qualities of a gumball machine as in Figure 1.



Figure 1: *Gumball Dreams* Poster [Photo Credit: Screaming Color, Stephen Butchko]

## 2 HISTORY

In under three years, Ferryman Collective has managed to go from an unknown group of creators to presenting work at some of the

biggest festivals in the world, pioneering the emerging storytelling genre of live theatre in virtual reality (VR). This group of theatre-makers came together during the pandemic to create their first production, *PARA*, a twenty-minute proof-of-concept in October of 2020, they then produced *Krampusnacht* that December, a finalist for the PGA Innovation Award. Wanting to explore the power of intimacy that can be cultivated in VR they teamed up with CoAct productions, adapting the in person immersive experience *The Severance Theory: Welcome to Respite* to VR, where it went on to premiere at top festivals, garnering multiple awards, before it was licensed by GiiÖii Immersive Storytelling Studio for audiences in South Korea.

Their 4th production, *Gumball Dreams* had its world premiere at SXSW where it won the Audience Award for XR Experience Competition. It then went on to have an International Premiere at the 79th Venice International Film Festival, and it's Asia premier where it was the Winner of the VR Golden Fire Ball Award at the Kaohsiung Film Festival. It played at the Denver and Imagine Film Festival before winning 'Best Immersive Performance' at Raindance Immersive. *Gumball Dreams* was named the XR Must Winner of: Creator of the Year, Best 2022 Experience, Best Live Experience.

Recently, they teamed up again with GiiÖii, to bring an English language version of their VR theatrical show *Find Wiilii* to SXSW this year. Ferryman Collective continues to bring live theater to public audiences, universities and conferences while collaborating with outside creators to develop new works.

### 3 DESIGN AND IMPLEMENTATION

*Gumball Dreams* was inspired by two 3D puzzle worlds, Club Gumball and Gumball Lounge, that previously existed in VRChat created by Christopher Lane Davis, aka Screaming Color. The first draft of the *Gumball Dreams* script was written by Deirdre V. Lyons and developed further with Christopher Lance Davis, who then worked on combining the two worlds into one while adding in UI features so the actors can run the show cues while performing. The show was built within Meta Quest 2 parameters so the show would have the widest audience possible. Deirdre V. Lyons worked with the nine actors trained to play the dual role of Cardiff and Onyx along with Stephen Butchko as assistant director.

Developed for one actor, the characters in the show were designed so that they disregard stereotypical gender roles, with alien avatars created by Brian Tull, each one unique, they still look like

they belong to the same race of beings, however the actor who embodies Onyx has an avatar that hints at a much older being. Cardiff (avatar created by Braden Roy) our onboarding and offboarding character is an AI robot, who has the job of oriented the audience to the space, helping audiences learn the mechanics that they will use during the show and make sure their menus are set for an optimal viewing experience.

Producer Whitton Frank is one of the performers along with Brendan Andolsek Bradley, Stephen Butchko, Melinda DeKay, Kelly B. Jones, Dasha Kittredge, Deirdre V. Lyons, Jonathan David Martin and Ona Zimhart. Some of the most experienced VR actors in the world.

### 4 APPLICATION

Live theater in virtual reality is an emerging genre of storytelling that feels tailor made for immersive theater, where interactivity, intimacy and immersion are prioritized. While traditional theater has dominated around the world, immersive theater tends to be available only in large cities. Bringing this artform into VR, audiences are no longer limited by geographical location and may experience this form of storytelling from their homes in a VR headset, giving accessibility and experience to those who haven't been fortunate enough to participate in a live immersive show in real life.

### 5 CONCLUSION

In the modern world, we are inundated with pre-recorded and pre-scripted content. Film, television, gaming, web, video clips on social media. It isn't surprising that this is our chosen method of storytelling, as the scalability is obvious. Theatre, and any live event doesn't offer the ability to share it with a million of your friends, unless that moment is captured on one's mobile device, and in that moment, it ceases to be live. It lives in a space that is uniquely its own, a space that is about the moment, connection, collaboration, and community.

Sharing a space with actors and other audience members gives a sense of intimacy and participation. Each performance is its own distinctive experience that can never be duplicated, even when the script and all the other elements are the same, the human element will always exert its effect upon the performance, allowing the feeling of presence that is not possible in a pre-recorded experience. Broadway is now digital.